The 1965 war had additionally raised serious questions about the reliability of India's external benefactors. The British reaction during the war elicited the most public Indian criticism.[6] The Soviet middle-of-the-road stance disappointed many who were used to Moscow tilting toward Delhi rather than Rawalpindi. There was also significant concern about the reaction and reliability of the US on four fronts. First, there was concern about the seeming lack of American response to China's threats. Years later, Indira Gandhi would still reference the lack of US assurances during the crisis. Second, there were questions about the reliability of US assurances vis-à-vis Pakistan.[7] The Pakistani use of American military equipment during the war had raised serious doubts about the US ability and willingness to restrain Pakistan. This was even more worrisome because India depended on the US to restrain Pakistan in the case of another Sino-Indian conflict.

Third, the US suspension of the agreed-upon June 1964 military package left Delhi believing that India did not have much to show for all the concessions it had made.[8] Moreover, there was a sense that the suspension of parts delivery had delayed defense production in India by requiring it to start from scratch with other countries.[9]

Finally, the US suspension of economic assistance—required, among other things, for the nation building that would strengthen India against China—reinforced the doubts about US reliability that Johnson's short-tether policy had created. The continued suspension of economic aid was a "shock," as Indian finance secretary Subrahmanya (S.) Bhoothalingam put it, and contributed to the feeling in India of being "let down by friends on whom they had counted."

Responding to American criticism that the war had shown that India was too focused on defense rather than development, Bhoothalingam indicated that China remained India's main problem, and the US needed to see Indian defense expenditure in that context.[10] Within the Indian government, if anything, US and Soviet behavior during the war had reinforced the desire to build an independent capacity so India could defend itself.

American officials argued, in turn, that instead of military spending, India could help solve its China conundrum, especially its Sino-Pakistan dimension—by settling its Pakistan problem.[11] India-Pakistan differences only created opportunities for Beijing, thus defeating the purpose of US